



Antelope Canyon

Beautiful chambers sculpted by flash floods, hidden beneath the Arizona desert

In northern Arizona lies one of the American Southwest's most-visited canyons, but few passing drivers know that it exists. This is because, unlike most other canyons, whose broad gorges open to the sky, Antelope Canyon is a slot canyon. Also called narrows, slot canyons have nearly vertical, twisting walls divided by fissures that can be just a handspan's width at the surface yet plunge downward for thousands of feet.

A tale of two canyons

Antelope Canyon was discovered in 1931 on land owned by the Navajo Nation. It twists and turns beneath the desert for 5 miles (8km); some sections are only a few feet wide, but can be 120 ft (36m) or more deep. The canyon has two parts: Lower Antelope Canyon, known in Navajo as *Hazdistazí* ("spiral rock arches"), and Upper Antelope Canyon, or *Tse' bighanilini* ("the place where water runs through rocks").

The spiral-patterned chambers have been created by running water, but the process has been intermittent. Over millennia, the local red Navajo sandstone has been subjected not to constant scouring from a river but to rare yet violent flash floods. Whenever the nearby Antelope Creek overflows, water forces its way through the desert surface via tiny cracks; rocks and other debris carried by the floods help carve out the rainbow-colored corridors. Where the canyon widens enough to allow in sunlight, winds blow in sand, abrading the walls and changing the patterns and the floor levels.

Were it not for **floods** periodically **washing the sand away**, the canyon would have **disappeared long ago**



△ SANDSTONE SPIRALS

Shafts of light, created briefly when the Sun is directly overhead, illuminate the chambers of Upper Antelope Canyon. The lighting effect transforms the sandstone into a multicolored spectacle.

◁ RIBBON IN THE SAND

Antelope Canyon's snakelike shape is best seen from above. Antelope Creek periodically forces its way through the canyon, its waters cleansing and altering the winding course before draining into nearby Lake Powell.